

‘Honesty should be non-negotiable’ – comms lessons from the Post Office Horizon scandal

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ABSTRACT (ENGLISH)

In a culture where there’s openness and transparency, people should be able to speak up without fear of reprisal and work together to solve the problem. * A lack of listening to employee voices is cited as a contributory factor in almost every negative corporate scandal. Stephen Waddington, managing partner, Wadds Inc The recent ITV document and Nick Wallis’ book shine a harsh light on the ongoing scandal. Tim Jotischky, divisional managing director for reputation, The PHA Group With the benefit of hindsight, it is hard to imagine how a scandal of this magnitude was allowed to happen: the sheer scale of it; the length of time it took to unfold; and the consequences for its victims – all simply defy belief. [...]once Horizon’s shortcomings became clear the cover-up began.

FULL TEXT

ITV's four-part series *Mr Bates vs The Post Office*, broadcast between 1 and 4 January 2024, has caused controversy with viewers.

The television drama recounts the fight for justice by either former or serving sub-postmasters and sub-postmistresses and their families who were prosecuted because of faults with the Horizon computer system used to assist with accounting.

In response to the *Mr Bates vs The Post Office* television drama, the Post Office’s chief executive Nick Read said:

“We sincerely apologise to victims for the devastating impact of the Post Office Horizon IT scandal on the lives of so many. We are doing all we can to provide redress and urge anyone affected who has not yet come forward to do so.” A statutory inquiry, chaired by Sir Wyn Williams, is currently examining the scandal.

Tech and IT provider Fujitsu, which provided software support to post office branches, said in a statement to PRWeek UK: “The current Post Office Horizon IT statutory inquiry is examining complex events stretching back over 20 years to understand who knew what, when, and what they did with that knowledge.

“The inquiry has reinforced the devastating impact on postmasters’ lives and that of their families, and Fujitsu has apologised for its role in their suffering.

“Fujitsu is fully committed to supporting the inquiry in order to understand what happened and to learn from it. Out of respect for the inquiry process, it would be inappropriate for Fujitsu to comment further at this time.”

The impact of the ITV drama touches on several important elements for comms and PR professionals, specifically reputation and crisis management. PRWeek asked crisis comms experts to discuss the main lessons for PR professionals.

Ed Whitehead, director of corporate and reputation, Fleet Street

Calls for a criminal investigation into those in charge of the Post Office during the Horizon Scandal are set to get even louder after *Mr Bates vs The Post Office*. Time will tell whether there was indeed a ‘cover-up’ of bugs in the accounting software, but there are some clear lessons we can learn:

The truth will out. This is the counsel that any reputation consultant worth their salt will give during a crisis. The best thing for a company’s reputation in the long term is to accept short-term pain by acknowledging what has gone wrong and taking clear steps to address it. Failure to ‘front up’, as in this case, could lead to years of investigations,

legal proceedings, media coverage, reputational damage and even financial ruin.

You need real leadership. An immediate ‘mea culpa’ may well be the best way for a business to start to move on, but it takes a strong chief executive to take responsibility for a crisis. Their whole career could be on the line.

The importance of reputational ‘money in the bank’ . A good reputation will give you the benefit of the doubt in a crisis, and a more receptive audience for your story in times of need. As recently as 2019, the Post Office claimed to be “the nation’s most trusted brand” , and while that trust has now been significantly eroded, I would argue that a scandal like this would have destroyed a business that didn’t have such strong reputational equity in the first place.

Ann-Marie Blake, co-founder, True Communications

“Lessons must be learned.” These four words are often heard when there’s been a disaster or scandal, yet in my opinion they very rarely are. For lessons to be learned, there needs to be an honest assessment of what went wrong, and why, and deliberate changes put in place to prevent repetition rather than just empty words. It’s encouraging to see the current chief executive talk about making significant changes to the Post Office culture and rebuilding trust, and it will be interesting to hear postmasters’ views of how this is progressing.

The Post Office scandal has been named the biggest miscarriage of justice in British legal history. While we hope it will never be repeated, hope is not a strategy, so here are some observations and lessons to think about:

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First, encouraging transparency and insisting on honesty should be non-negotiable for everyone working in communications. Every professional PR code has ethical guidelines, although you should not need guidelines to tell you that reassuring staff a system is robust when it is not is clearly wrong.

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I’ve been around enough technical and software implementations to know that bugs sometimes happen. Be open about the situation. Covering up is almost certainly going to make the matter worse. In a culture where there’s openness and transparency, people should be able to speak up without fear of reprisal and work together to solve the problem.

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A lack of listening to employee voices is cited as a contributory factor in almost every negative corporate scandal. So take time to listen.

Stephen Waddington, managing partner, Wadds Inc

The recent ITV document and Nick Wallis’ book shine a harsh light on the ongoing scandal. It’s too early to evaluate the level of corporate malpractice, but it is clear that numerous failures contributed to the crisis.

The Post Office initially accused its employees of false accounting and fraud and then blamed the Horizon system from Fujitsu. A failure of leadership, management processes and decision-making created this crisis.

The Post Office management acted to protect the brand's reputation. A failure of stakeholder management and transparency had the opposite effect.

The collective action of Post Office employees, an activist campaign led by Alan Bates, reporting by *Computer Weekly* and journalists such as Nick Wallis, and the work of a tenacious group of MPs have resulted in the current level of public interest and inquiry.

This is a human tragedy. The Post Office dug in and aggressively pursued prosecutions without any care for the impact on individuals and families, even after flaws in the Horizon system came to light. Only after extensive legal defeats did it admit flaws and apologise.

The scandal highlights failures in corporate governance, leadership, and lack of transparency. Those in positions of management and responsibility must have checks and balances to avoid this kind of single-minded decision-making and doubling down on mistakes.

Amanda Coleman, crisis communication practitioner and founder, Amanda Coleman Communication

One of the most important issues was the inability of the Post Office to listen to the problems and understand what was happening. Reputation is built from many elements and being able to deal with problems effectively is a key part. The first step in effective crisis management is to recognise you have a crisis, which the Post Office failed to do. Leaders have to be ready to listen to feedback externally and internally and sometimes this will be challenging and painful.

What matters most to me is to remember that each of the more than 700 cases is about real people, real lives, and businesses have to understand and reflect on that. For PR and comms it is not enough to provide facts; you have to acknowledge the emotion, and with this scandal, there are some devastating consequences that still feel like they have not been accepted.

The fact that this situation has existed for two decades and that steps were never taken despite the information that people had is horrific. It may be tough, but PRs have to call out organisations that may be attempting to cover up a crisis. And never try to diminish the severity of a situation that has clearly destroyed people’s lives. Be open, be honest, accept your problems and listen so that you can respond with empathy and humanity.

Tim Jotischky, divisional managing director for reputation, The PHA Group

With the benefit of hindsight, it is hard to imagine how a scandal of this magnitude was allowed to happen: the sheer scale of it; the length of time it took to unfold; and the consequences for its victims –all simply defy belief.

From a crisis communications perspective, a few points can be made.

First, Horizon was a complex product and too few people in the Post Office understood its shortcomings properly. From the outset this was never challenged and the mindset became that if the product was beyond reproach, then the people using it must invariably be to blame. That defied common sense. You did not need to be an IT expert to challenge that narrative and ask tougher questions of the suppliers, Fujitsu. In a crisis, asking the most simple and obvious questions at the outset is essential.

Secondly, once Horizon’s shortcomings became clear the cover-up began. An organisation can recover from a crisis if it acts with sincerity and transparency. Instead, the Post Office retreated into a culture of denial.

Thirdly, the initial instinct in a crisis can be to conceal apparently minor failings to protect the organisation from reputational damage. But once this happens, the reputational damage is invariably greater once the truth emerges –and in a crisis it usually does. Subject access requests and the right to freedom of information make it harder than ever to conceal wrongdoing.

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